

Social connection linked to improved health and reduced risk of early death

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The World Health Organization (WHO) Commission on Social Connection has released its global report revealing that 1 in 6 people worldwide is affected by loneliness, with significant impacts on health and well-being. Loneliness is linked to an estimated 100 deaths every hour—more than 871 000 deaths annually. Strong social connections can lead to better health and longer life, [the report](#) says.

“In this Report, we pull back the curtain on loneliness and isolation as a defining challenge of our time. Our Commission lays out a road map for how we can build more connected lives and underscores the profound impact this can have on health, educational, and economic outcomes,” said Dr Vivek Murthy, Co-chair of the WHO Commission on Social Connection, and former Surgeon General of the United States of America.

WHO defines social connection as the ways people relate to and interact with others. Loneliness is described as the painful feeling that arises from a gap between desired and actual social connections, while social isolation refers to the objective lack of sufficient social connections.

"In this age when the possibilities to connect are endless, more and more people are finding themselves isolated and lonely," said Dr Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus, WHO Director-General. "Apart from the toll it takes on individuals, families and communities, left unaddressed, loneliness and social isolation will continue to cost society billions in terms of health care, education, and employment. I welcome the Commission's report, which shines a light on the scale and impact of loneliness and isolation, and outlines key areas in which we can help people to reconnect in ways that matter most."

Scale and causes of loneliness and social isolation

Loneliness affects people of all ages, especially youth and people living in low- and middle-income countries (LMIC). Between 17–21% of individuals aged 13–29-year-olds reported feeling lonely, with the highest rates among teenagers. About 24% of people in low-income countries reported feeling lonely — twice the rate in high-income countries (about 11%).

"Even in a digitally connected world, many young people feel alone. As technology reshapes our lives, we must ensure it strengthens—not weakens—human connection. Our report shows that social connection must be integrated into all policies—from digital access to health, education, and employment," said Chido Mpemba, Co-chair of the WHO Commission on Social Connection and Advisor to the African Union Chairperson.

While data on social isolation is more limited, it is estimated to affect up to 1 in 3 older adults and 1 in 4 adolescents. Some groups, such as people with disabilities, refugees or migrants, LGBTQ+ individuals, and indigenous groups and ethnic minorities, may face discrimination or additional barriers that make social connection harder.

Loneliness and social isolation have multiple causes. They include, for instance, poor health, low income and education, living alone, inadequate community infrastructure and public policies, and digital technologies. The report underscores the need for vigilance around the effects of excessive screen time or negative online interactions on the mental health and well-being of young people.

Impacts on health, quality of life and economies

Social connection can protect health across the lifespan. It can reduce inflammation, lower the risk of serious health problems, foster mental health, and prevent early death. It can also strengthen the social fabric, contributing to making communities healthier, safer and more prosperous.

In contrast, loneliness and social isolation increase the risk of stroke, heart disease, diabetes, cognitive decline, and premature death. It also affects mental health, with people who are lonely twice as likely to get depressed. Loneliness can also lead to anxiety, and thoughts of self-harm or suicide.

The impacts extend to learning and employment. Teenagers who felt lonely were 22% more likely to get lower grades or qualifications. Adults who are lonely may find it harder to find or maintain employment and may earn less over time.

At a community level, loneliness undermines social cohesion and costs billions in lost productivity and health care. Communities with strong social bonds tend to be safer, healthier and more resilient, including in response to disasters.

A path to healthier societies

The report of the WHO Commission on Social Connection outlines a roadmap for global action focusing on five key areas: policy, research, interventions, improved measurement (including developing a global Social Connection Index), and public engagement, to shift social norms and bolster a global movement for social connection.

Solutions to reduce loneliness and social isolation exist at multiple levels – national, community and individual – and range from raising awareness and changing national policies to strengthening social infrastructure (e.g., parks, libraries, cafés) and providing psychological interventions.

Most people know what it feels like to be lonely. And each person can make a difference through simple, everyday steps—like reaching out to a friend in need, putting away one's phone to be fully present in conversation, greeting a neighbor, joining a local group, or volunteering. If the problem is more serious, finding out about available support and services for people who feel lonely is important.

The costs of social isolation and loneliness are high, but the benefits of social connection are far-reaching.

With the release of the Commission report, WHO calls on all Member States, communities and individuals to make social connection a public health priority.

[Access the full report here](#)

Editor's notes

The report launch follows the first-ever resolution on social connection, adopted by the World Health Assembly (WHA) in May 2025, which urges Member States to develop and implement evidence-based policies, programmes and strategies to raise awareness and promote positive social connection for mental and physical health. At the WHA, WHO also announced a new campaign called “ [Knot Alone](#)” to promote social connection for better health. Tune in to WHO's social media channels to follow the campaign.

As part of its broader efforts, WHO has also launched the Social Connection Series to explore the lived experience of loneliness and social isolation. Learn more about the series [here](#).